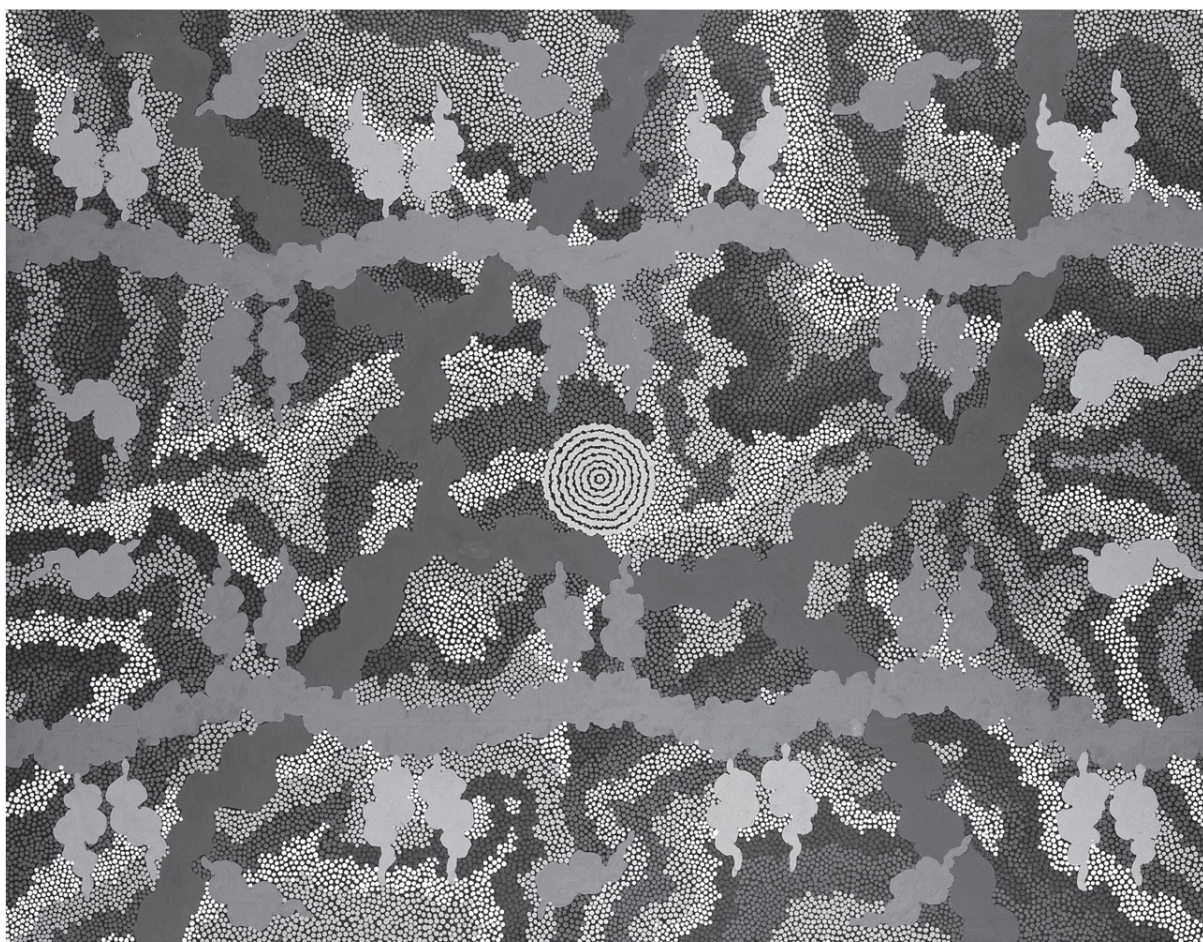


Aboriginal Dreamtime

Australian Aboriginal art has always been closely linked to spiritual beliefs and mythology. The Dreamtime describes myths that are the basis of Aboriginal society and have lasted for thousands of years. The Aborigines believe the land they occupied was once completely empty until, during the Dreamtime, the land and sky were formed by supernatural, mysterious beings who rose from the earth and took human, animal or plant form. These Spirit ancestors continue to wander the earth, leaving sacred tracks.

Creatures of the Dreamtime include the Rainbow Serpent, All-father and All-mother figures. The arrival of Europeans saw the Aborigines dispersed and assimilated, but some traditions were retained, and Dreamtime forms the basis of Aboriginal art. Many artists now paint in acrylic on board, but their abstract work retains older elements – intense colours and symbolic motifs, wavy lines, dots and concentric circles. Prominent artists include Emily Kngwarreye (c.1910–96), Ginger Munduwalawala (c.1936–2002), Clifford Tjapaltjarri (c.1932–2002) and Rover Joolama (c.1926–98).



Clifford Possum Tjapaltjarri, *Corkwood Dreaming*, 1992